



The Freedom SONG

INDIA, THE MODERN NATION, WOULD HAVE TO BE DIFFERENT FROM THE RELATIVELY MONOLITHIC EUROPEAN MODELS ON OFFER. UNITY, YES, BUT WITH MANY A DIFFERENCE.



Sitora Das

CELEBRATING INDEPENDENCE: National Anthem being sung at Rashtrapati Bhavan

BY PRIYAMVADA GOPAL

Recently I met a young Chinese filmmaker. We compared notes on the paths our two nations had taken over the last six decades. Very different journeys in so many ways but both marked by a much-hyped opening up of national economies to the powerful forces of market globalisation. He spoke of the enormous state repression faced by Chinese artists, intellectuals and ordinary citizens despite their increasing consumer power and the vast choices available to them in television sets and fancy cars. For some, India, with its strong democratic traditions and vibrant public sphere, was a source of fascination and envy. Perhaps, he said wryly, China too would have benefited from a dose of colonial rule.

In an amiably provocative way, he was echoing the familiar canard that